

STAGE THIRTEEN • TEAMWORK & COLLABORATION

FIRSTS

FACILITATOR NOTES / SCRIPT

Suggested language for openings, transitions, and prompting discussion

A Citrus Edition Facilitator Resource • Companion to the FIRSTS Manual

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FIRSTS • Facilitator Notes / Script

Stage Thirteen • Teamwork & Collaboration

HOW TO USE THIS SCRIPT

This document is written for a first-time or less confident facilitator who wants actual suggested language, not just a topic list. Everything in quotes is meant to be read close to verbatim, or adapted lightly into your own voice.

Stage Thirteen works with real teams, which means real, sometimes messy group dynamics can surface during a session — someone dominating a discussion, a team that can't agree, a retrospective that stays superficial. Part 3 and Part 4 of this script are built specifically around those moments.

It's organized into four parts: session openings, transitions between FIRSTS, discussion prompting for five specific situations, and tricky moments flagged at specific FIRSTS where real team dynamics commonly complicate the exercise.

Part 1 — Session Openings

Opening Session 1

“Welcome to Stage Thirteen. This stage is the peer-level counterpart to Stage Twelve's leadership focus — today isn't about leading a team, it's about being a genuinely strong team member, whether or not you hold any formal authority.”

“Most of what we cover today works best applied to a real, current team project. If you have one, keep it in mind throughout. If you don't, we'll form a temporary working team for the day so everything still has something real to attach to.”

Opening Session 2

“Last time was about setting a team up well: alignment, roles, norms, a real plan. Today is about the actual day-to-day work of collaborating — documentation, tools, and working across real differences in function, culture, and location.”

“If your team has people from different functions, cultural backgrounds, or working remotely, that's genuinely useful today — several exercises benefit directly from real diversity in the room.”

Opening Session 3 (Stage Close)

“Our final session covers harder territory: conflict, difficult teammates, and honest retrospectives. This asks for more honesty than the previous two sessions, and that's intentional — high-performing teams don't avoid difficulty, they navigate it well.”

“We'll close today by combining several practices from across this entire stage on one real team experience, not just recalling them individually.”

Part 2 — Transitions Between FIRSTS

A few sentences said out loud between exercises and between sessions turns a checklist into a coherent narrative.

FIRST Q1 → Q2

"You've confirmed the team is genuinely aligned on wanting to work together. Now let's make sure everyone's actually aligned on what you're working together toward."

FIRST Q4 → Q5

"You've agreed on how you'll work together. Let's put that agreement to use immediately by building the actual project plan together, not separately."

Session 1 → Session 2

"Yesterday was about setting the team up well. Today is about the real, ongoing work of collaborating — the tools, the habits, and the genuine differences you'll navigate together."

FIRST Q13 → Q14

"You've confirmed your team is using shared tools together. Now let's look at a different kind of coordination challenge — working across genuinely different functions, not just different task lists."

FIRST Q16 → Q17

"We just covered remote collaboration broadly. Asynchronous work is a specific, related challenge within that — let's get concrete about what genuinely self-contained communication looks like."

Session 2 → Session 3

"You've built real skill working alongside your team day to day. Our final session covers what happens when that work gets genuinely hard — conflict, disagreement, and honest reflection."

FIRST Q22 → Q23

"We just talked about navigating one difficult relationship. Let's zoom out to the whole team — how do you reach a real, genuine decision when the group doesn't naturally agree?"

FIRST Q26 → Q27

"You've just practiced genuine celebration. Now let's balance that with the other, harder half of closing well — an honest look at what actually worked and what didn't."

Part 3 — Prompting Discussion in the Moment

Five situations that come up often in this specific stage, with suggested language for each.

A team can't agree on roles or delegation (Q3, Q8)

"Let's separate two questions: who's genuinely best suited for this task, and who's interested in growing into it. Those aren't always the same person, and naming that explicitly usually unlocks the conversation."

Someone dominates a brainstorm or discussion despite structure

"Let's make sure we've heard from everyone before we go back to anyone. [Name], I want to come back to your point in a moment — let's hear from [quieter person] first."

A participant is reluctant to name a real, current team conflict (Q21–Q22)

"You don't need to name who it's with or the specifics. Just naming to yourself that a real tension exists, and thinking through how you'd approach it, is enough for today."

A team's retrospective (Q27) stays surface-level and avoids real failures

"What's one thing that, if we're honest, genuinely didn't work? It doesn't have to be anyone's fault — just something worth naming so it doesn't repeat."

Someone says their team never actually reached consensus, only a vote (Q23)

"That's really common, and useful to notice. What would it have taken for the dissenting view to feel genuinely heard, even if the final decision stayed the same?"

Part 4 — Tricky Moments by FIRST

Four specific FIRSTS (some spanning a short arc) where real team dynamics commonly complicate the exercise — and language to navigate each moment.

FIRST Q21-Q22

Team Conflict Resolution & Difficult Teammate Experience

FACILITATOR NOTE

Participants may want to process a real, current, unresolved conflict live in the room. Redirect this to a private conversation with you after the session rather than turning group time into real-time mediation of someone's actual, ongoing dispute.

FIRST Q23-Q24

Team Consensus Exercise & Team Compromise

FACILITATOR NOTE

These can surface real frustration if a participant recalls a past team decision that was pushed through without genuine buy-in. Let that frustration be named without turning the exercise into re-litigating the specific past incident — redirect toward what a better process would have looked like.

FIRST Q27

Team Retrospective

FACILITATOR NOTE

Teams genuinely new to honest retrospectives may default to only listing positives. Model this yourself first if needed — share one honest thing that didn't work in how you've facilitated so far, which gives explicit permission for the team to do the same.

FIRST Q30

High-Performing Team Experience

FACILITATOR NOTE

Some participants may feel this FIRST asks for more than a single session realistically allows, since it's meant to be applied over a sustained project. Frame it explicitly as a forward commitment — naming the combination of practices they'll apply going forward — rather than something that must be fully demonstrated today.